30 November 2025 — קריאת התורה: Sacred Protocols and the Legacy of the יקעס

Independent review · written from the finished HTML only (the version before the Sefaria corrections); no transcript or summary material used in the findings · 18 October 2026

1.Overall Read

A sixteen-section write-up (roughly 4,800 words of body plus a twenty-note *Mareh Mekomos* apparatus of about 1,700 words) in three movements: a personal preface (I); a long historical answer to the question why Frankfurt did not say בריך שמיה, running through the Geiger brothers, Hirsch, שבתי צבי and the Ashkenazic suspicion of קבלה (II–VIII); and a walk through the Torah service, from גדלו לה' אתי to the division of honors (IX–XVI). The first movement is moving, the second has the most vivid material (the brothers, the secession, the Amsterdam חרם) and the most problems, and the third is clear and practical but loosely connected to the first two.

The hard editorial issues are seven: (a) **chronology and dating conflict between body and notes** (the first printing of the זוהר; how and when בריך שמיה entered the סידורים; the dates of Rav Shlomo Zalman Geiger); (b) **unsourced narrative claims presented as settled** (the Amsterdam חרם, the מהרש"א, the חפץ חיים's private practice, the "known מעשה" of a defective scroll); (c) **several note–body contradictions and unresolved "verify" instructions** (notes 4, 5, 6, 8, 10, 16, 17, 18); (d) **Section XV conflates two calls and two songs**; (e) **a source title in Section XIII that the note itself doubts**; (f) **a mismatch between a name and its note in Section XIV**; and (g) **live-shiur residue and first-person voice** throughout. Fixing these would make a very readable chapter.

2.What Works

- **The reframing in Section V.** "The question is not why Frankfurt did not say בריך שמיה. The real question is: why did *we* start saying it?" is the best moment of the write-up; it turns a curiosity about one community into a question about the whole Ashkenazic world and justifies the long history that follows.
- **The two brothers (III).** The contrast between Rav Shlomo Zalman, who stayed with the מנהגים, and Abraham Geiger, who removed ירושלים from the liturgy, and the thread through Hirsch's חברותא at Bonn, gives the reader a human way into the story.
- **The sequence of opponents of קבלה (V).** שבתי צבי → Amsterdam → חתם סופר → מהרש"א → נודע ביהודה → the א"רמ's principle is built in an order that supports the claim, each step with a distinct point (a ban, a silence, a ruling, a rule).
- **The balance of Section VI.** The turn to the בעל שם טוב and the חפץ חיים's advice to read even without understanding gives the opposing view fair weight, and the closing line about Frankfurt's steadfastness is earned.
- **The six steps (IX).** The story of דוד המלך, the Ark, מיכל, and the stop every six steps is told cleanly and ends exactly where the question started (why this verse, why six words). It is the strongest teaching in the third movement.
- **The practical sections (X–XIII)** are short, discrete and each carries a single point (escort; gaze; why after; an uncommon honor; a custom for an expectant father), which suits a book.
- **The personal preface (I)** is well controlled, with an arc (forgetting, the reminder, the dedication) and the "Between Two Worlds" callout adding depth without sermonizing.
- **Note discipline.** Twenty notes, numbered in body order with back-

links, and most carry a short and an expanded form.

3.Where It's Weak or Could Be Sharper

The printing of the תורה and the arrival of שמיה contradict the notes. Section II says the תורה was first printed in 1557 in שטא קיסרי that "within a few decades … שמיה appeared in nearly every תורה," and that "by the mid-1600s it was standard practice." Note 1 says the standard attribution of the first printing is Mantua 1558–60 and Cremona 1559–60, and that the passage came into mainstream סידורים especially via *שערי ציון* (Prague 1662)." A reader cannot hold both: if the passage entered through a 1662 book, it cannot have been universal "by the mid-1600s." Either reconcile (say what "standard" means and for which editions) or present the shiur's timeline as reported and put the correction in the note's first sentence.

The dates for Rav Shlomo Zalman Geiger do not fit the body. The body says he served as a דיין in Frankfurt "in the late 1700s and early 1800s … for many years." Note 2 gives (1792–1878), publication of *זמירי קהלת* 1862, and calls him the *older* brother of Abraham Geiger (1810–1874). A man born in 1792 cannot have been serving as a דיין in the late 1700s. Choose the period (probably the mid-nineteenth century if the note is right) and make the body agree. The same sentence places the whole discussion before the 1862 date of his own book, which a reader will notice.

Narrative claims without sources. (i) The Amsterdam גזירה (a decree to surrender the ה"תורות within three days) is stated with specifics, a פנקס הקהילה as the source, no date and no note. (ii) "The א"מהרש writes: I do not want to hear from הוריו" is given as a quotation; note 5 says the quotation "should be cross-checked." (iii) The סופרים statement is given as a שאובה with no מקור; the note says it is "from his own אגרות and biographical sources," which is not the same thing. (iv) "There is a known משנה of a גלגול discovered after התורה את had been said" is unreferenced. (v) The Hirsch material (eighty families; תקופות something that had simply not been done in Germany before") is asserted without a note;

the latter is, as far as I know, overstated, since dancing on שמחת תורה was known in German communities.

Section VII is the hardest to follow. It carries three separate arguments (the phrase ויראת אלהים and fear of the authorities; the Yerushalmi on Nebuchadnezzar; the phrase אנא עבדא and a fourth, the ץ"בגר, that depends on a source the reader is not given. "If the section is a piece from elsewhere" and "ר"ש בי himself elsewhere says you may not say בני אלהים" where does ר"ש בי say it? Without that, the argument cannot be evaluated. The Yerushalmi paragraph also says "at the end of ראשית" when the פסוק says אלהים, but the מתרגם renders it בני האלהים"; this is not at the end of ראשית as far as I know, and "we are forbidden to call them אלהים" is unclear (who are "them"?). The line "These are dangerous claims to repeat publicly" is followed by repeating them; a book should say what it means to say, with the appropriate caution, or say less.

The חיים ץ"בגר paragraph (VIII) is confusing about people. "His grandson, Hillel Zaks — the זאקס family is well known; one זאקס is a son-in-law of the חיים ץ"בגר, and מנדל זאקס was a ראש ישיבה in YU": it is not clear whether Hillel is the grandson, or son or son-in-law of someone, or whether Mendel is the son-in-law, and note 10 adds a different arrangement. The anecdote itself (the חיים ץ"בגר did not say שמיה משום because he did not wish to say אנא עבדא) is a striking claim resting on a single, unsourced testimony; present it as reported, name the witness correctly, and say so.

The quotation of the verse in Section IX. The text quotes "גדלו ה' אתי וגו' ממה שמו יחדיו" and counts six words. As far as I know the verse (תהלים ד:ד"ה, as note 11 says) reads "גדלו לה' אתי" with a ל prefix on the divine name; the count of six is right for the verse as it stands but the text as printed has dropped the ל. The heading uses אתי, the body אתו; pick the verse's form.

Section XII has a likely slip. "The גלילה who performs גלילה" appears to be גולל (the one who rolls the scroll), which the context supports ("rolling and binding"). The first-person lines ("I have never seen any shul sell it … I have

never seen it") are the lecturer's, and a sefer should either attribute them or drop the first person.

Sections XV and XVI. Section XV says the gabbai "announces כיצד that this is a call for silence, and that משה רבינו before he sang the שירה of אז ישיר called out אז ישיר ". זמירות ט"ו is the Song at the Sea (ו"ט זמירות) and האזינו opens the Song of האזינו ב"ה. they are two different songs, and, as far as I know, the call that the gabbai makes is על הבו גדל לאלהינו while כתוב is called by the עולה. The section may conflate two calls; note 19 gives ב"ה:א:ב Section XVI says the מדכי רבים מורים that each action may be split "and assigned to different people," then lists three persons, while note 20 says the principle underlies "the standard contemporary practice of selling each item separately": assigning and selling are different things, and the note's list (replacing, closing) goes beyond the body's three.

4.Factual / Citation Concerns

Note 1 (פרשת ויקהל ר"ו ע"א, ד"ה חלק ב)	The note opens by correcting the body ("the standard scholarly attribution … Mantua 1558–60 …"), then states how the passage entered the מדורים; the correction should be in the text, not only here. The locus (ויקהל vol. II) is, as far as I know, the standard place of כריך שמיה, but the folio was not checked.

Note 2 (דברי קהלת)	Dates (1792–1878; "Frankfurt, 1862") conflict

with the body's "late 1700s and early 1800s." The note calls him "the

leading codifier" and "the older brother of Abraham Geiger (1810–1874)";

the two are not both in the body.

Note 3 (בחקתי, משך חכמה)	The reference to "the famous concluding

is general. Give the verse (probably "ו:מ"ד	and a short quotation of the Hebrew; the body's "Berlin was their reader's whole evidence.

Note 4 (שאל "ת חתם סופר")	A flagged unresolved "verify exact

biographical citation"; the body calls it a	the note says

Move to endnote with an honest caveat or supply the reference.

Note 5 (מהרש"א)	"The shiur's specific quotation should be cross-

checked." The note adds a genealogical remark ("their shared lineage

runs through the Heller family") that is not in the body and is stated

without a source; "Lublin (his קבר) was a major center" is a non-

sequitur, and I am not sure the א"הרש is buried in Lublin.

Note 6 (נוסח ביהודה) "Verify exact סימן the short form gives two

responsa (ד מהדורה תניינא צ"ג; או"ח קמ"ז) while the expanded form

says the principal one is ג"צ. The body says "in two תשובות;

reconcile.

Note 7 (דכי משה) The cross-reference to "ה ס"ק מ"ב" משנה ברורה כ

is unexplained; no סימן is given for the דכי משה

Note 8 (ו ה"ט; פסחים קי"ח ע"א) "Verify exact location" (ושלמי שבת פ

is left in the note, along with a second cross-reference to that פסחים

the note does not explain. The quoted Aramaic ("ג':כ"ה"),	דָּמֶה לְבַר אֱלָהִין
should be checked against the printed text. The body's "	כבר אלהים s
not the verse's wording.	

Note 9 (יג"ץ)	**יג"ב**	The note describes the argument and says it "uses
passages such as the	כבר אלהים	language" as evidence, which the body
does not support with a citation; "Cited cautiously by the shiur" is a		
production note.		

Note 10 (ד"מ)	**משנה ברורה קל**	Ends with "Verify the biographical
citation in printed Chofetz Chaim biographies." The family detail in the		
note (R' Mendel Zaks, son-in-law) differs from the body's phrasing (see		
above).		

Note 11 (מחזור ויטרי; א"כ)	**אודרהם**	The verse is quoted without the	ל

(see Section 3). The attribution to the	חזור ויטרי is given only in

outline.

Note 12 (ברכות ס"ג ע"ב – ס"ד ע"א; פרק ו')	The note says **שמואל ב**

"sextuplets every birth"; the body says "his daughters had sextuplets."

Check against the printed Gemara. The body's "the	discusses **הרא**

different	regarding what was brought" is not referenced; give **שיטות**

the page.

Note 13 (עץ חיים; ד")	**מסכת סופרים פרק י**	No halachah number;	עץ חיים

without a	The body's "The **שער**	says one walks the **שלחן ערוך**	**ספר**

to the **הורה**	is unreferenced. **מובא**

Note 14 (או"ח קל"ד,)	**מגן אברהם** No	the body's "known **עיף קטן**

has no note. **נעשה**

Note 15 ((	**1250–**	**1180)**	**אור זרוע** Gives dates and a character

sketch but not the	the claim that the	אור זרוע treats the various

כיבודים. including … handing the	and	ארטל is the very point

of Section XII and needs a reference.

Note 16 (מורה באצבע /	**מחזיק ברכה** The short form names two

works; the body names a third (	which the note (מחזה כהונה תמרי תקניין

says to "verify." The body bolds a title the note doubts, and I am not aware

of a work by the א"	with that name.

Note 17 (ר' חיים פלאג'י …	**כף החיים** The short form combines two

authors of works with the same name (	כף החיים of יעקב חיים סופר	ר

and of חיים פלאג'י	) and ends with "likely	חיים ח"ר Unresolved.

Note 18 ((ת מהרש"ג (שם אריה	**ש** The body names the ג"	מהרש as

"the	שם אריה, the note says the	אינם אריה is another author's work

and asks the reader to "verify which work is intended." This is a

contradiction left in the text.

Note 19 (סדור הרוקח; מחזור ויטרי;	**מאבודרהם**	**בכו)**	Quotes	האזינו

(דברים ל"ב:א')	שמים ואדברה, see Section 3 on the conflation.

Note 20 (מרדכי;	**אור זרוע**	See Section 3. No	מסכת	for the ימין

מרדכי

Unannotated claims. The Amsterdam	מגן, the	מפץ חיים in	ראדין

the	childlessness מיכל (ו':כ"ג)	שמואל ב, and any Gemara on it;	משנה

ברורה on	שמיה בריך (named in the body, in note 10 only as "ד"	ל"ק;	

the א"	ד"ה	מוסר on talking during the removal of the scroll (the body	

gives no source); the א"	ד"ה	view that שמיה בריך is to be said before	

the removal.

5.Small Polish Suggestions

- **Hebrew density.** Almost every noun is a Hebrew inline span, so the English spine is hard to read aloud. Adopt the series convention: transliteration first, Hebrew in parentheses on first use, then one form.

- **Live-shiur residue.** "Last week we began," "Next week בעזרת השם," "whose קבר we visited in Lublin," "I am sponsoring today's breakfast," "this is the gabbai's domain," and "Last night I discovered" are spoken. Mark them or replace with a neutral voice.
- **Voice of the callout.** The "Between Two Worlds" callout shifts into first-person memoir and an aside ("I once attended יום העצמאות services …"). It works, but name the grandfather (and the father) once with their Hebrew names and drop the rest of the first person.
- **Dedication.** "לעילוי נשמת ר' יעקב אליהו בן ר' אשר אנשיל הי״ד" can be read as saying that the first man was killed; a book reader needs a sentence of explanation, or the הי״ד should be attached unambiguously.
- **Transliteration drift.** בריך שמיה is the form used; Hebrew forms vary (פראנקפורט/פרענקפורט; זאקס/זקס; גייגער/גייגר). Pick one for running text.
- **Terms of art** (יקעס, פנקס הקהילה, פארברענטער, הגבהה, פתיחה, KAJ) are used without gloss; one-time glosses would serve a general reader.
- **The header and footer** contain production notes ("Reworked from the original שיעור"; "Hebrew terminology preserved in Hebrew script throughout"); reduce to a dateline.
- **Section order.** Section IV (Hirsch and the future of German Jewry) interrupts the answer; a bridging sentence at the opening of V ("we

return to the question") would help. Section XIV's last paragraph (the מהרש"ג) belongs more naturally after IX.

6.Bottom Line

A readable and often vivid chapter whose centre (the Geiger brothers, Hirsch, the long Ashkenazic suspicion of ה', and the six steps of the Ark) is close to publishable. It needs work before print: reconcile the chronology of the ־ and of שמיה ־ with note 1, and the dates of Rav Shlomo Zalman Geiger with note 2; supply or soften the sources for the Amsterdam ז, the ז סופר, the א" ש־ and the חפץ ו story; clear the notes that still read "verify" and the contradictions between body and note (notes 16, 18); restore the verse in Section IX to its form; untangle the two calls and two songs in Section XV; and strip the spoken voice. With these, it can stand as a lively chapter in the tefillah series.

Produced by an editorial review pass reading only the finished HTML document. Where a statement of fact is flagged "as far as I know," it rests on general knowledge and not on a source consulted.